Subdivisions Controlled by Pattern Headings

H 1146

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A. Background

The principle of free-floating subdivisions controlled by pattern headings was officially incorporated into Library of Congress Subject Headings in 1974. Standardized sets of topical and form subdivisions were developed for use under particular categories of subject headings or name headings used as subjects. To avoid repeating these subdivisions under all possible headings, only one or a few representative headings from each category are established in the subject authority file with a set of the subdivisions appropriate for use under other headings belonging to the category. Such headings are called pattern headings for their respective categories.

Because many subdivisions that are now authorized as free floating by a pattern heading were printed in Library of Congress Subject Headings prior to 1974, they still appear in the subject authority file in numerous instances in combination with individual headings belonging to a category. In addition, some headings incorporating free-floating subdivisions controlled by pattern headings are established because they are needed to provide the reference structure for other headings.

Free floating subdivisions that are listed on H 1095, the list of form and topical subdivisions of general application, are not usually established in the subject authority file under pattern headings. However, some general free floating topical and form subdivisions are established under individual pattern headings if they represent an important topic or type of material relevant to the category, or if they are cited as examples in general see also references (cf. H 371) or general see references (cf. H 374). Free-floating form and topical subdivisions of general application are not repeated on the separate lists of free-floating subdivisions controlled by pattern headings. The pattern heading lists contain only the additional free-floating subdivisions that are pertinent to each category. In addition, subdivisions that are authorized for free-floating use under a broader category that encompasses the pattern heading category are no longer separately listed on individual pattern lists. For example, the subdivisions ***--Patents*** and ***--Trademarks***, which are authorized for free-floating use under types of articles and products on H 1095, are not listed on H 1195, the pattern list for land vehicles. However, these subdivisions remain free-floating under land vehicles since land vehicles are a type of product. Therefore, it is frequently necessary to consult H 1095, H 1100, the list of free-floating subdivisions used under classes of persons, and H 1105, the list of free-floating subdivisions used under corporate bodies, in addition to a specific pattern heading list when constructing subject headings with free-floating subdivisions.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Textbooks***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. General rule

Use any subdivision that is established under a pattern heading as a free-floating subdivision under any other heading belonging to its category if it is appropriate and if no conflicting heading is established in the subject authority file in either phrase or main heading-subdivision form.

For example, a set of subdivisions was developed for use under headings for organs and regions of the human and animal body. Typical anatomical headings belonging to this category include ***Alimentary canal***; ***Autonomic ganglia***; ***Renal artery***; ***Thymus***; ***Toes***; etc. Two pattern headings are designated to represent this category: ***Heart***, as an internal organ, and ***Foot***, as an external region. A subdivision established under either of these headings may be

used as a free-floating subdivision under any other heading for a part of the body if it is appropriate to the specific heading and does not conflict with a heading established in the subject authority file in another form. To illustrate, the subdivision ***--Biopsy*** is established under the pattern heading ***Heart*** and is listed on H 1164, the pattern heading list for organs and regions of the body. It may be used as a subdivision under the heading ***Joints*** even though no specific authority record exists for the combination ***Joints--Biopsy*** in the subject authority file. On the other hand, the subdivision ***--Dislocation*** is established under the pattern heading ***Foot*** and is also listed on H 1164. However, it may not be used as a subdivision under the heading ***Joints*** because the combination ***Joints--Dislocation*** is a UF reference under the general heading **Dislocations** in the subject authority file.

Note: Subdivisions that are established under pattern headings and are applicable only to those specific headings are not, for all practical purposes, free-floating. Such subdivisions were deleted from these lists in 1994. Examples include ***--Antiochene rite***, which is established under the heading ***Catholic Church*** and was formerly listed on H 1187 *Pattern Headings: Christian denominations*; ***--Right ventricle***, which is established under the heading ***Heart*** and was formerly listed on H 1164 *Pattern Headings Organs and regions of the body*; and ***--Aircrew survival equipment***, which is established under the name heading ***United States**. **Navy*** and was formerly listed on H 1159 *Pattern Headings: Military services*.

Except where specifically allowed, do not combine subdivisions that are separately listed on lists of subdivisions controlled by pattern headings to form extended subject heading strings. For example, do not construct the heading ***[animal]--Reproduction--Seasonal*** variations based on the individual subdivisions ***--Reproduction*** and ***--Seasonal variations*** from H 1147. Instead, assign two headings. On the other hand, a heading in the form ***[animal]--Fractures--Treatment*** may be constructed because an instruction in H 1147 states that the subdivisions authorized for use under ***[animal]--Diseases*** may also be used under other subdivisions on the list that represent specific pathological conditions. Consult additional free-floating lists for further subdivisions that may be used under subject headings in general or under heading/subdivision combinations that represent broader categories, such as scientific topics, types of buildings, structures, etc., or products and commodities (H 1095); classes of persons (H 1100); and legal topics (H 1154.5).

D. New subdivisions

To add a new subdivision to the list of subdivisions used with a particular category, establish the subdivision under the appropriate pattern heading for that category in the normal manner (cf. H 200). Follow the procedures in H 371 to make a general see also reference to the new free-floating subdivision from the general heading that corresponds to the concept represented by the subdivision. Provide the pattern heading as an example in the general see also reference.

See H 371 sec. 4 for the standard wording to be used in formulating general see also references for each category. When no general heading exists for the concept in the subject authority file, consider establishing the general heading at the same time, or if that is not feasible, make a general see reference to the new free-floating subdivision according to the procedures in H 374.

Do not establish the new subdivision under the specific heading needed for the work in hand if it is applicable to a pattern heading and other headings belonging to the category. Instead, establish it under the pattern heading for the category in which the specific heading fits.

E. Exception

Any subdivision that is not appropriate for use under the pattern heading(s) of a particular category is not eligible to be added to the list of pattern subdivisions established for the category, nor can it be granted free-floating status. When such a subdivision is required for a work being cataloged, establish it under the specific heading assigned to the work. If the subdivision is subsequently needed for another heading belonging to the category, the usage must be established in a similar manner under the second heading.

For example, a work in hand is about the topic of refractive errors of the eye. Since the concept of refractive errors is applicable to neither ***Heart*** nor ***Foot***, a subdivision ***--Refractive errors*** must be established under ***Eye***.

F. Conflicts

Subject authority records may exist for headings governed by a pattern heading and employing variant phrases or subdivisions equivalent to a subdivision on a pattern list.

LC practice: If an exceptional variant form is to be retained, make a UF reference from the equivalent free-floating subdivision form following the procedures in H 195 if the reference does not yet exist. Otherwise, submit a proposal to change the variant form along with all bibliographic records requiring correction following the procedures in H 193.

G. Headings representative of the category

The individual pattern lists provide guidance on the types of headings covered by each category. Treat headings as belonging to a category only if they represent examples of the class of entities described by the category designation. The heading representing the whole class, which usually corresponds to the category designation, is generally not included. For example, the pattern list for materials (H 1158) covers headings for individual materials and types of materials, such as ***Rubber*** and ***Composite materials***. The general heading ***Materials*** is excluded from the category.

H. Pattern heading lists

Lists of the free-floating subdivisions controlled by pattern headings follow as H 1147-H 1200. On each list the usage of some subdivisions is explained in endnotes. Subfield coding is provided for each subdivision.

I. List of pattern headings and their categories

Below and on the following pages is a chart showing the pattern headings designated to date. They are arranged first by major discipline, then by special category.

Note: Pattern headings have not been designated for all possible categories in the world of knowledge. Not all headings in the Library of Congress Subject Heading system are covered by pattern headings.

I.1. Religion

Category	**Pattern heading(s)**	**SHM**
Religious and monastic orders	Jesuits	Consult H 1186
Religions	Buddhism	Consult H 1185
Christian denominations	Catholic Church	Consult H 1187
Sacred works (including parts)	Bible	Consult H 1188

I.2. History and Geography

Category	**Pattern heading(s)**	**SHM**
Colonies of individual countries	Great Britain--Colonies	Consult H 1149.5
Legislative bodies (including individual chambers)	United States. Congress	Consult H 1155

Military services (including armies, navies, marines, etc.)	United States--Armed Forces United States. Air Force United States. Army United States. Marine Corps United States. Navy	Consult H 1159
Wars	World War, 1939-1945 United States--History--Civil War, 1861-1865	Consult H 1200

I.3. Social Sciences

Category	**Pattern heading(s)**	**SHM**
Industries	Construction industry Retail trade	Consult H 1153
Types of educational institutions	Universities and colleges	Consult H 1151.5
Individual educational institutions	Harvard University	Consult H 1151
Legal topics	Labor laws and legislations	Consult H 1154.5

I.4. The Arts

Category	**Pattern heading(s)**	**SHM**
Art	Art, Chinese Art, Italian Art, Japanese Art, Korean	Consult H 1148
Groups of literary authors (including authors, poets, dramatists, etc.)	Authors, English	Consult H 1155.2
Literary works entered under author	Shakespeare, William, 1564-1616. Hamlet	Consult H 1155.6

Literary works entered under title	Beowulf	Consult H 1158.8
Languages and groups of languages	English language French language Romance languages	Consult H 1154
Literatures (including individual genres)	English literature	Consult 1156
Musical compositions	Operas	Consult 1160
Musical instruments	Piano Clarinet Violin	Consult 1161

I.4. Science and Technology

Category	**Pattern heading(s)**	**SHM**
Land vehicles	Automobiles	Consult H 1195
Materials	Concrete Metals	Consult H 1158
Chemicals	Copper Insulin	Consult H 1149
Organs and regions of the body	Heart Foot	Consult H 1200
Disease	Cancer Tuberculosis	Consult 1164
Plants and crops	Corn	Consult 1180
Animals	Fishes Cattle	Consult 1147

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.